MEDIATOR GUIDE TO CAREERS

Find professional fulfillment while building a career that's more than just a job

16Personalities

Table of Contents

Introduction **3**
Academic Path **5**
How Mediators Learn 6
Mediators in High School 10
Work or College? 15
Mediators in College 18
Lifelong Learning 24
Conclusion. 28
Professional Development **29**
Suitable Careers for Mediators 30
Career Alternatives 35
Workplace Roles 36
Mediators as Subordinates. 37
Mediators as Colleagues 41
Mediators as Managers. 45
Workplace Cooperation Between Types . . . 49
Mediator-Analyst Cooperation. 50
Mediator-Diplomat Cooperation. 54
Mediator-Sentinel Cooperation 59
Mediator-Explorer Cooperation 63
Conclusion. 67
Final Words **69**
So... What's Next? **70**

Introduction

Why Academic and Professional Development Matter to Mediators

Mediators have a reputation for being sensitive dreamers, not nose-to-the-grindstone productivity buffs. When people think of superambitious, hard-driving personality types, Mediators might not be the first to come to mind. But it would be a mistake to think that Mediators don't have ambitions or their own visions of success.

In their professional lives and on their academic journeys, Mediators want to feel inspired and fulfilled. They look for opportunities to share their creativity, grow their understanding, and whenever possible, make the world a bit brighter and more beautiful for those around them. Far from being unambitious, many Mediators have a clear and cherished vision for what they'd like to bring to the world, and in many cases, this vision involves pursuing a career that calls to them on a soul level.

That said, Mediators tend to be quite open-minded when it comes to their studies and their career path. Curious and imaginative, they may enjoy exploring multiple subjects as well as different types of jobs. While they ultimately hope to find their calling, they're able to see the potential of many different routes that present themselves along the way.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Transforming Challenges into Opportunities

Even though they are open-minded and adaptable, Mediators can still become discouraged when all doesn't go smoothly with their studies or their professional trajectory. With their big-picture thinking style, they may find it difficult to translate their dreams and ideas into tangible, daily tasks that help them make progress toward their goals. As a result, some Mediators unfairly view themselves as lazy or untalented, when in reality, they may just need additional support or accountability.

Another challenge that arises for many Mediators is their sensitivity. In many settings, this sensitivity is a wonderful trait that can enhance Mediators' empathy and insight, but it can also make them vulnerable to feeling personally hurt by criticism, whether or not that criticism is helpful or deserved. They may interpret negative feedback from a teacher or boss as a sign that they should give up and try something else, rather than viewing the situation in a way that's more balanced and holistic.

In this guide, we'll discuss how Mediators can bring their greatest gifts to their academic and professional paths. We'll also show them how they can reframe the challenges that arise along the way not as signals that they've gone astray, but rather as opportunities to develop, enhance, and share their gifts. In addition, we'll review how Mediators can lay the groundwork for productive, positive relationships, even with colleagues whose personalities are very different from their own. Our hope is that the insights in these pages will enable Mediators to find fulfillment, inspiration, and invitations to learn and grow as they move in the direction of their calling.

Academic Path

As a rare personality type that's not always well understood, Mediators often find that the psychological impact of school is especially relevant. These types stand out as unusual when compared to their fellow students, and the obligatory and objective nature of the classroom can exacerbate their naturally sensitive disposition. As such, their learning style presents distinct challenges both for themselves and their teachers, yet Mediators who embrace their unique style while working within a structured educational program can find tremendous success. By learning more about this personality type's inherent learning style and habits, educators too can enrich the lives of their Mediator students – and their own lives in the process.

Intuitive Learners

Mediators often don't know why they know things. Ideas and vague notions of how to navigate themselves academically seem to appear out of thin air for these types – like knowing how to write a well-planned essay without any outline whatsoever. They just know, without putting much thought into the how or why. What may seem like random bursts of knowledge, however, is really their subconscious absorbing information and connecting nearly imperceptible patterns.

Known as intuitive learning, this ability to channel coherent streams of consciousness into their work from these oh-so-subtle patterns makes them students who can grasp abstract concepts quickly, understand the meaning of the theoretical without being told, and easily and enthusiastically learn things outside the classroom.

However, as magnificent as the gift of intuitive learning is, it actively works against these types in conventional educational systems, as students who give concrete evidence that they're learning are those who reap the rewards. It's easy to see where the issue lies for Mediators whose thought processes are hidden – even from themselves.

Humanistic Relevancy

Mediators have a natural grip on topics that deal with people and interpersonal relationships. This isn't surprising, considering how attuned these types are with their own emotions. They use their feelings as a filter to view the world through. That's why courses that deal with the humanities – philosophy, literature, religion, art, music, history, and language – frequently lure Mediators into lengthy study. They frequently find themselves infatuated with fascinating academic topics.

These types require a strong personal connection to a topic in order feel fully invested, and they may wonder how important it is to learn material that they have no personal interest in. Consequently, these types usually take issue with standardized benchmarks. They find that strictly structured mandatory tests take away the spontaneous joy of learning. Their aversion to the mundane can lead Mediators to completely avoid, and perhaps discount, things outside their immediate realm of interest.

How Mediators Learn

Mediators are capable of being amazing students who mix Intuition with inherent precociousness, but these abilities can lead them away from well-rounded academic paths when they're given too much leeway. These types often find their greatest success by blending their academic resources with their own intuitions.

Balanced Learning Habits

Deconstructing the Intuitive

Mediators base their learning style in creativity, humanistic relevancy, and spontaneity. These types rarely need to dig deeply into individual details of a subject to start making deep connections. Typical learning

structures measure success based on assessments over details, so Mediators can feel overwhelmed and out of place in a traditional education system. However, there's no rewiring their brain to perform otherwise – nor should there be an attempt. A balanced approach to academics for Mediators requires a merging of existing structure with their unorthodox learning style.

The thought processes of Mediators provide them with answers first, from which they work backwards, deconstructing the larger subject into details, facts, and fundamentals. For example, these types may write an essay with little to no planning involved and then deconstruct the final draft at length. These types are apt to note the anatomy of their essay in detail, taking stock of the outline, techniques, errors, and revisions. Through this consideration of their spontaneous answers, Mediators clarify their own learning process and improve knowledge retention, which provides them with invaluable information for learning more efficiently and thoroughly in the future.

Mixing in Practicality

Mediators, like all Diplomats, find that subjects that focus on some sort of human factor resonate more with them than subjects that don't – they would rather write a supporting essay about how myths and fairy tales reflect modern day society than solve for "x." However, some also understand that there's a need for learning "mundane" skills, like taking the time to develop long-term study habits for classes that they don't enjoy. These Mediators develop this balanced approach because they understand that these skills, though not dreamy and inspiring, are necessary for everyday life.

Rather than shrugging off things that they aren't inherently interested in, these types dig in their heels and attempt to master the material in front of them. They're propelled forward by the sense that the drudgery of mundane subjects is only temporary and that the skills they're learning can support work that they consider meaningful.

Unbalanced Learning Habits

Skipping the Fundamentals

While pondering interesting ideas, Mediators' thinking may be too abstract to connect to the concrete learning going on in some classrooms. While the instructor is leading a very linear lesson where variable "a" interacts with "b" resulting in "c," Mediators may be massaging concepts only vaguely related to these lettered facts. For these types, "a," "b," and "c" work as a springboard for their thinking, and their ideas aren't dependent on any one of them. This doesn't mean that they aren't learning – they might even draw their own meaningful conclusions independently. Problems arise for these types, however, when they're unwilling to retrace their steps to understand how they arrived at their conclusions.

Mediators may not feel confident reciting facts and may find it hard to concentrate on details that they're expected to mirror on assessments like quizzes or exams. Many people complain that they feel competent as learners but they "don't test well" – Mediators can be especially prone to this. A Mediator taking an unbalanced approach to learning may completely discount grades and exams. This comes at their peril – these systems of evaluation act as communication between students, instructors, and schools. Forgoing these measures also forfeits the benefits that come from such understandings, whether within institutions or among trusted friends, and ultimately creates isolation and frustration with little good to show for it.

Narrow Interests

In many ways, Mediators are generalists. Their Prospecting trait keeps them jumping from interest to interest, giving them a wide array of things on which to focus. Still, they may quickly shut out anything that lacks direct appeal to their inspirational bent. Having narrow interests is one thing, but discounting topics outside that scope is something else. When Mediators dismiss what's outside their immediate interest, they run the risk of being unprepared to take their true interest to the next level, as advanced understanding of one thing may require a small understanding of all things. Without such context, they limit their ability to advance, narrowing their perspective – a travesty for those who value universal understanding.

Most students love some courses and dislike others. Mediators may take this to the next level, feeling no connection whatsoever to subjects like algebra, for example. They may bide their time and do the best they can to please teachers and parents while waiting to get to philosophy or history class. This superficial approach may get the job done – and by many measures it will be a job well done – but the value of the whole experience as an academic learning opportunity is thrown into question.

Rebalancing Learning Habits

Solidifying the Abstract

Communication is an important part of Meditators' learning style, and they solidify their abstract notions when verbalizing their thoughts or writing them out. While not necessarily shy, these Introverts may not be forthcoming with what they're thinking, as it's often unconventional or even fantastical. To avoid criticism, they may learn not to share their ideas. Nonetheless, the act of talking or writing about their thoughts – turning abstractions into words – can be helpful.

Mediators may feel reluctant to take on this task because it may first appear as a large mass of indecipherable information. It's like describing the shape of smoke. Before they can measure the ideas in their head, they must first contain them. This may seem difficult at first, but here are some things that they can do to ease the process:

- Read over some previously written work or write down new thoughts for about 30 minutes.
- After reading or writing, go over the work again and pick out the most prevalent/interesting/recurring patterns.
- Write down this observation in a plain-form sentence. Describe the pattern. Why does this pattern come up? Why did it stand out?
- Use this process of observation to distill your thoughts into clear points in your written work.

Facts Thrive with Context

When faced with a topic that doesn't lie within their immediate realm of interest, Mediators can reframe it into a more interesting context. One way is using mnemonic devices to deal with facts, especially if they're contained within a story or put in meaningful, and perhaps even human, context. This works for all ages, but is particularly useful for adolescent Mediators.

There are a lot of ways to couch unrelated facts in things of interest. Where others may see memorization as an education goal, this task is more ancillary to the Mediator learning process. These types aren't "anti-facts" as much as they don't focus on them in favor of bigger ideas. Creative mnemonics may be the spoon of sugar that helps the medicine of cold facts go down for them.

The ways to attract Mediators to fact-based learning are almost endless, but some creativity may be necessary when it comes to engaging with them in some subjects. Consider this mnemonic device that combines the planets in the solar system with stories from mythology:

- Swift-footed Mercury is closest to the Sun and so, like the god, runs fastest around our star.
- Next is Venus, named after the goddess of love and beauty, as it's also the most stunning thing in the sky.
- War-like Mars glares red and angry at its nearest neighbor, Earth, who holds a coveted place closer to his lover, Venus.

This blends literature and culture with cold facts about the planets and their locations. (When it comes to Mediators, adding a poetic feel doesn't hurt either.) Such a combination makes learning a list of planets more palatable to these creative types.

Mediators in High School

Mediators are perfectionistic in their ideals – and in high school they begin to look at the world as a place that holds meaning and takes dreams seriously. This adds enough gravitas to the high school experience that these insightful individuals do well overall. In their striving to maintain harmony, these types work hard to get grades

that please parents and teachers. Although their burgeoning presence in the world propels them to excellence even in challenging subjects, Mediators often must pay special attention to whether a course is too mundane or detail oriented for them.

Balanced High School Learning

Curious and Idealistic

The childlike wonder and curiosity of Mediators is a strength that lets them joyfully hop from topic to topic, making instant connections along with their inclination to easily communicate abstract concepts. In environments where structure and standardization are preferred, Mediators can find approaches to guide their curiosity in more practical ways rather than quashing it all together.

By creating a high school schedule that works with their interests, they can develop points to look forward to during a long day of subjects that they may not exactly be interested in. An art class, for example, where they can freely pursue their painting passion, can serve as encouragement for them to pay attention to required courses as they pursue their own passions as well.

Making the Mundane Interesting

The courses that speak to Mediators most are the humanities and social sciences. Literature, language, history, political science, psychology, philosophy, and similar subjects resonate best with these students, who are riveted to any course that includes overcoming human dilemmas. Commiserating with characters from well-written stories appeals to both their imaginations and their emotions, and studying an individual or culture from history feels like home for these learners.

Much of the zeal that Mediators show for a social studies course disappears if a teacher assigns lists of dates to memorize – any learning by rote class will lose their attention. These types prefer a class that's lighter on the hard facts, and they connect far more with Hamlet's existential crisis than the physical properties of uranium. A proper synthesis of the two might grab these types, however – pair that same uranium discussion with an account of Marie Curie's

trailblazing accomplishments as a scientist and the subject becomes more meaningful and interesting for Mediators.

Unbalanced High School Learning

Uneven Attention to Subjects

When a subject comes easily to them, Mediators may not apply themselves to learning. They may take it for granted that they'll do well and not put as much effort into tests and papers, especially if the subject doesn't excite them personally.

Mediators aren't typically bound by conventional rules and structure in their inner lives. They wouldn't necessarily perceive neglecting a subject that comes easily as laziness on their part – the bigger picture always takes priority for these types, and putting a lot of labor into seemingly mundane or unimportant work may seem senseless. Mediators won't lose sleep at night over their own lackadaisical attitude. They'll probably do just as well anyway, regardless of whether they invest time and attention.

However, this easy success isn't always wise. Even the smallest details have value – learning discipline independent of how it feels is a valuable life lesson. In fact, the more these students step out of their comfort zone, the broader their influence on the world around them, and the more likely they are to experience personal growth. This doesn't mean that these types should give up their inherent Mediator strengths – simply that expanding their repertoire of behavior beyond what they're used to and prefer can be the best way to address their priorities.

Relying on Intuition

It's at this stage in life that Mediators begin to realize that natural precociousness may not be enough. At an early age, they may have learned that their inherent talent was enough and that studying wasn't necessary. This fixed mindset begins to fail them in high school as things like structure and studying become more important to academic success than what their Intuition can readily provide.

Instead of recognizing that their habits are keeping them from well-rounded knowledge, they may blame themselves for not being smart enough or working hard enough. They can fall into the trap of believing that there's no room for growth and that their natural talents fall short of what's needed to succeed.

Rebalancing High School Learning

Creating a Personal Path

The main issue within Mediators' academic careers is that their learning style doesn't quite fit the mold. In high school, learning how to create efficient ways to utilize their creativity can benefit them most throughout life. While covering the required benchmarks, these students can work at home in customized, independent ways that allow them to learn in their own style.

Mediators can motivate themselves to deal with courses that feel mundane and narrow by reminding themselves that discipline can work in all parts of their life. These types might not show much enthusiasm for algebra, but learning the material despite a lukewarm attitude can be a great exercise in self-growth. Like all Diplomats, the idea of becoming someone better is always lingering in the background for Mediators. If they reframe any subject as an exercise in personal development rather than an exercise in math (or science, or geography), they may find the energy needed to engage more fully in the subject. Of course, this may be asking a lot of most adolescents. However, if nothing else, it answers the question, "How will I ever use [subject] in my life?" Answer: You can use it to learn to become more disciplined.

Here's how Mediators can create personal paths that fit their academic needs:

- Consider a required subject that they're not particularly interested in.
- Research a prominent figure in the subject – consider Katherine Johnson for mathematics, for example.
- Find out why this person was a revolutionary in their time.

Developing a Growth Mindset

Carol Dweck, a renowned professor of psychology, has developed a working theory called "Growth Mindset" that focuses on motivation, learning, and the problem with the idea of a "fixed mindset" – the idea that individuals are unable to learn anything beyond what they're naturally good at. Mediators can easily fall into this "fixed mindset," as they're told from a young age that they're gifted and talented and often resent themselves for not remaining so as they grow older. To fix this, they must first reframe "can't" into "not yet."

The consequence of this "fixed mindset" is an aversion to risking failure or success, as either could "disprove" the innate qualities that Mediators see within themselves. By embracing failure, or even success, these students can grow exponentially within their academic careers.

Here are some steps on how Mediator students can embrace failure:

- Consider one failure. This could be a single assignment, a course, or an entire subject of study.
    - What about this experience makes it a failure? Take notes.
- Revise this failure into an opportunity.
    - Then, write about that source of failure as an opportunity for growth. A failed exam shows that the material could be better understood. A failed course shows an instructor or set of ideas that never quite clicked. A failed subject shows an area of expertise that is something to work for.
- Gather information about how this could improve.
    - Speak with the instructor who taught during this moment of failure about improvement. Did they notice any specific or persistent problems?
    - Look up educational resources: test-taking strategies, study help for the subject, flash cards...
- Ask for help setting expectations. Sometimes failure is a difference in how people define success, and by following other standards, it's easier to recognize where those differences lie.
- Consciously accept lessons that occur from the experiment.

Work or College?

The question of whether college is the right option is important. For some, it's a natural move that requires little forethought. Others may ask if college is something that they want to pursue or when they want to pursue it. So-called "gap years" are becoming a more popular option as busy students seek to catch their breath before taking their seats at their chosen universities. Older adults are more regularly pursuing degrees later in life. Some individuals who see the success of college dropouts like Bill Gates or Steve Jobs wonder if getting a degree is worth it at all.

While all students need to examine their motives for going to college, Mediators need to more than others. They're almost compelled to find meaning and authenticity in all that they do. Participating in anything that doesn't fit their exacting standards leaves them experiencing regret and dissatisfaction.

Balanced Decision-Making

Taking the Steps Needed

Mediators may see college as a step to a career. However, they're unlikely to see a career as the be-all and end-all reason for making their choice. It can lead to a career, they may think, but can the experience enhance their lives as well? Can college help them grow? Or can they learn more from going straight into the working world? While their sometimes dreamy approach to life may indicate otherwise, those who take a balanced approach to choosing college or work take practicality into consideration. Dreams, after all, won't pay the bills.

It's also not far-fetched to say that, with their unconventional thinking, some Mediators may choose alternative lifestyles off the conventional economic grid. This might mean choosing a "grow your own" style of self-reliance over joining the traditional workforce. These types understand their responsibilities enough to actively participate in keeping themselves alive and thriving – they may take off the beaten paths like exploring the world for a year or becoming sustainable farmers in far-off countries.

Understanding Their Reasons

These students know that only they can make the decision to go to college. Pressure from family or other people in their lives can lead to disaster – Mediators must see higher education as aligned with their unique values to invest themselves fully. Other types may be okay going to college just because others expect it of them – Mediators find such expectations problematic.

Jobs right out of high school also need a sense of purpose for Mediators. Choosing employment simply to mark time and make a few dollars won't work for them any better than going to college without a good reason. However, "good reasons" sometimes come in interesting forms. Higher education often serves as a stopgap for young adults until they figure out what they want to do with their lives. Young Mediators may want to explore this option if their search for a meaningful type of work comes up empty. College can be a chance to explore ideas and discover new vistas while hunting for a job title that truly fits.

Unbalanced Decision-Making

Appealing Only to Instinct

Mediators' Prospecting trait may push them toward too many diverse interests. Their Intuition sees a big world, and their Prospecting trait wants to reach out and embrace it all. It can be difficult for some to choose a path. It may be easier for them to acquiesce to the wishes of others if their own desires are too overwhelmingly complex.

This is a personality type that doesn't always make strong cases based on objective facts. There are times when going on instincts works well. However, there are other times when adhering to facts is essential. Mediators might rely too heavily on an almost spiritual direction in deference to their Intuitive and Feeling approaches to life. While powerful intuition is a gift, when used in an off-balanced way it can counter reasonable arguments and lead to poor decisions.

Mediators need one foot on solid ground and the other in the heavens, metaphorically speaking. Deciding something as important as whether to attend college or not may be one of these occasions. Since going to

college is such a significant investment of time and money, deciding whether to or not needs to combine both rationality and instinct.

Selecting for Others

The opinions of parents or other admired mentors are important to many people, and to Mediators especially. Family may come first for these types, and they make sure to include their loved ones in most aspects of their lives – past, present, and future. Always conscientious of societal expectations, they may pick routes that are deemed "proper" or "acceptable" by authority figures in their lives.

It's at this point that these students can begin down a path of passive living – letting powerful loved ones have the majority say of the choices in their lives – even if they're choices that Mediators don't particularly like.

Rebalancing Decision-Making

Choosing Their Own Path

In many areas of life, these types may need to spend time deciding what they want and separating it from what others want. If people-pleasing is part of their college decision, they can rebalance this by pushing themselves to discover their true preference in reasonable yet assertive ways. However, Mediators who are standing their ground need to understand that they can't be responsible for the reactions of others. The college decision is one that affects their lives. Making the decision that suits them best is the highest form of authenticity in this matter. That alone may help motivate them to make their own choices.

Once they explore the hard facts, they can then start asking, "What is it that I want?" "What would give my life the most meaning now?" "Am I doing this to make someone else happy, or is it the right thing for me?" Some of the answers may be complex and take some time and thought. However, the objective is to avoid doing something simply as an act of pleasing others. While this doesn't mean that others can't be pleased, Mediators need to be faithful to their values and aspirations. Without them, they're not likely to benefit from involvement in college – or anything else, for that matter. Here's a small exercise that can help:

Mediators can answer the following questions with one- to two-sentence responses, trying to remain as clear and concise as possible.

- When do you feel engaged and enthusiastic, work- or academic-wise?
- When have you overcome a difficult challenge successfully?
- When have you achieved peak performance?
  - What were you doing at the time?
  - What were the principles that you followed?
  - What did you do to reach your goal?
  - Did you feel personally satisfied with that accomplishment?
- Bearing in mind the challenges that you face now (and possibly in the future), how can you build on what you know works?

When these types become aware of what works for them, it makes the decision of choosing work or college somewhat easier. And the information gathered through this assessment applies throughout the lives of Mediators, if they're creative in how they apply it.

Mediators in College

After their more limited high school experiences, Mediators may find that they're finally home when they enter the hallowed halls of higher education. College can certainly cater to their artistic tendencies. There may be more opportunities to exercise their powerful imaginations and to approach some topics from the "What if?" perspective that all Diplomats cherish. The shift from high school to college ratchets up Mediators' excitement for learning.

In the college setting, where they'll likely find approval for their intellectual curiosity, these types can spread their Intuitive wings. Mediators are allowed, perhaps even encouraged, to explore the ideas that the high school curricula couldn't accommodate. Communication often becomes central to what these students do in college. They often write impassioned pieces about subjects that they feel are important, in the process learning the value of critical thinking and purposeful

writing. These types can grow into impressive writers or even orators, often with a poetic flair.

Balanced Approach to College

Selecting the Right Courses

Mediators tend to discover that most college courses are pleasantly challenging. These types have the passion to do well in any niche they choose, though they're likely to engage more in courses with a humanistic bent which allow them to feel genuinely connected to the subject that they're learning. Mediators need to know that their work speaks, either to them or for them – anything less leaves them unsatisfied. Since there's much more latitude in college, students can more readily select courses that speak to them. As in high school, those that fit this bill are likely to be courses that they can connect with personally, rather than those simply needed for future financial success.

When a human element is involved, it changes everything about a course. Medicine can draw Mediators if they possess a vision of the subject that exceeds labs and medical codes. These types might well anticipate a practice with a holistic approach that includes spiritual and cultural considerations, and that's enough to help them trudge through the weeds of science to prepare for a psychiatric or clinical practice. When the reasons *why* are compelling enough, Mediators may tolerate any number of specific *hows* or *whats* presented in the classroom, even against their typical inclinations.

The Right Motivation

Those who take a balanced approach find subjects that resonate within themselves and then find a way to make that passion a reality, whatever challenges may be present. They search through several fields, learning from each until they've settled on one that feels right.

Mediators go to college to explore ways to gain more insight and help others become better people in a holistic sense. Of course, these types understand that they must make a living to survive. In consideration of their financial needs, they may try to find ways to combine making

a living with that which benefits society. However, the allure of courses that foster their growth in some other way than just as a commodity or a cog in the economic machine is always there.

Unbalanced Approach to College

No Room for Imagination

In every college career, there are unappealing but necessary courses, often under the larger umbrella of obligation that is "prerequisite courses." Statistics courses may not appeal to Mediators interested in psychology, for example, yet they're a required and necessary tool in the discipline. As it was in high school, Mediators may respond in such courses by exerting minimal effort. This is never a comfortable way for these types to operate – they may complete the courses, even successfully, but with the recognition that they've just gone through the motions. This can feel like a waste of their time and even a bit phony.

It's also conceivable that Mediators inspired by the newfound freedom of higher academia may not bother to put in minimal effort in courses that don't fulfill their expectations. They may instead pursue things that resonate more fully with them and simply neglect the rest. They may feel they're being authentic – and their GPA may authentically drop to match.

By disregarding the fundamentals, these types undermine their foundation. In our example, statistics is a requirement for psychology majors because statistical literacy is essential for applying that psychology effectively. A half-hearted effort limits Mediators' ability to pursue their interests meaningfully, leading to dissatisfaction that can extend far beyond the college years.

Missing the Flow

Along the same lines, there may be times when Mediators' Intuition cobbles together ideas that aren't easy to explain and aren't constructed in a simple linear fashion. While other students are walking through the steps to a conclusion, these types may find it annoying to wait for an answer by adhering to a more organized, critical process. They may think they've connected the dots, not realizing how many dots they've

missed. This rush to provide answers can hold Mediators back when processes become complex enough that instinct alone isn't enough. This can lead to frustration and perhaps withdrawal from the system – and a consequent abandonment of achievement in this aspect of their lives, further leading to that ever-present potential of an unfulfilling life.

Beyond that, there's a certain tyranny in needing the last word, even in an individual's own mind. Mediators are open-minded. However, once they've decided that something is true, when something falls outside the realm of this truth, they can become stubborn. It's not that they're "hardheaded" as much as they believe that they're honoring the truth – they're likely to simply let alternative facts wash over them without consideration at all, as their Intuitive trait rejects a reality check.

Not all professors are open to students questioning their material. Also, fellow students may say things that sound too conventional to Mediators. These types understand that their unique perspective can have them needlessly challenging standard academic material. However, when it comes to the truth as they see it, those who take an unbalanced approach may feel that they need to push forward and stand their ground – oddly, by withdrawing from the situation, especially mentally and emotionally, into their own safe world.

Conflicts arise when Mediators see a need to both create harmony and maintain their sense of authenticity. Suppose they're asked to write an exam essay reflecting the thoughts of a professor with whom they don't agree. What happens when their professors or classmates insist that they accept or write something that they don't believe is true? The decision to stand their ground for the "truth" or simply play along can cause lots of anxiety within these students. It can feel like a no-win scenario.

Rebalancing Their Approach to College

Prerequisites as Self-Help

As in high school, Mediators may need to approach duller courses as workouts in self-discipline. Reframing these courses from meaningless inconveniences into a training regime may help students find value in

them. Life imposes necessary but boring things on everyone. Detail and memorization that a more strictly defined course requires, with the right attitude, can help them become better at tolerating and dealing with the mundane.

Many worthwhile things may happen if Mediators adjust their attitude. Firstly, they may gain discipline that provides much-needed balance to their more free-form way of thinking. They may learn the value of being stricter with themselves when it comes to life's more insistent details. Secondly, they can view the time spent in such classes as valuable, rather than a useless and artificial waste of time.

To change their perception of unappealing classes, Mediators can try these tips:

- Review the syllabus carefully to get a clear feel of the course. Sometimes refreshing expectations puts Mediators back on the same page as others.
- Alongside the main course objectives and deadlines, Mediators can create small, fun tasks for themselves that align with the course. Studying European History? Read a Wikipedia article or two (our suggestion? Start with Boudica, the Celtic warrior queen) and follow links wherever the interest leads.
- Divide large projects and assigned readings out to manage an undesirable workload. Reading, say, five difficult pages a night over three weeks instead of 100 difficult pages over a three-day slog can make something tedious into something halfway enjoyable.
- Allow time to explore the course in whichever way is preferred. Some units and lessons don't appeal in any way, while others captivate – this is natural. Mediators need to follow their interests and can do so here.

By following these tips, Mediators can find that learning is a joyful and authentic experience that allows their natural curiosity to run free while also completing all course requirements.

Humbly Genuine

When these types need to reproduce ideas that they don't agree with in

papers and on exams, it can be trying for them. Mediators can become stuck in their need to be true to themselves, which might prove impractical as they are, after all, college students learning the truths of the world around them.

A possible solution is to consider the rules of improvisation. Those comedians and actors who practice improv are trained to say, "Yes, and..." to everything. They accept a premise and find a creative way to add to it, even if the premise they're accepting is ridiculous. To avoid conflicts while maintaining integrity, Mediators may want to start thinking of the classroom as an improv club and every moment they're called on to speak as a chance to explore a new possibility.

By practicing this, these students can decide ahead of time to accept the standard thesis of a lecture as the recognized premise for the class. They can accept that an instructor who has dedicated considerable time and effort to their subject is now trying to impart new knowledge to them, an act that's inherently commendable. Mediators now accepting the standard can add any of their flourishes whenever opportunities arise.

They can apply this concept with the following steps:

- Consider a subject that doesn't perfectly align with accepted beliefs.
- Consider the subject as it is to find inspiration in it.
  - Subject: Trigonometry
    - What has mathematics meant for humanity?
    - It leads to medicine and the creation of enough food. It was integral to the Enlightenment era's unprecedented growth of human potential and well-being from illiteracy and starvation.
    - Math is a metaphor for this human growth.

Using this approach, Mediators can both enjoy the idea that they're being true to their understanding of something while maintaining harmony with others.

Lifelong Learning

Lifelong learning goes beyond the rigors of school, though a return to academia is certainly an option. Older Mediators who have embraced themselves fully are better able to give the benefit of the doubt to areas of study or schools of thought that might have struck them as irrelevant – or worse – in their younger years.

Balanced Lifelong Learning

Tempered Idealism

If personality types had superlatives, then Mediators would be awarded "Most Idealistic." Their idealism persists throughout their entire academic career and colors what they want to learn, how they learn it, and how long it takes them to master the subjects that interest them. They're easily excited by the prospect of learning something new, but when they discover how much time and effort is required once they're further along in the process, they'll often feel disappointed. Mediators with a more balanced approach reign in their idealism every so often and learn to ruminate less and implement more.

Consider learning Japanese, for example. It may begin with an interest in a cultural aspect of the people who speak that language – having an online friend from Japan, for instance – which then inspires them to take that next step. The balanced approach is seeing the language learning process as personally meaningful and therefore worthy of practicing more and more, perhaps with a goal of one day visiting Japan. Mediators draw on so many facets of an experience for lifelong learning – their sense of adventure, their inspirations, their culture, their drive for growth, and their curiosity – all while staying true to their own strengths.

Work and Play

Mediators have difficulty enjoying learning when the subject at hand is, as they see it, boring. And "boring" by their standards usually means "highly technical" and otherwise lacking their favored humanistic traits. While they may feel inclined to completely abandon these subjects, most Mediators ought to consider their value and how learning about them can enrich their lives in the long run.

One of these values, for example, can be developing focus for work. It seems easy enough for most people, but Mediators typically have a particularly rough time concentrating on things that aren't personal priorities. They can learn to focus with time and effort, and then they'll find that homing in on even undesirable tasks is easy – the trick is getting there in the first place.

Unbalanced Lifelong Learning

Only Idealism

The world constantly enamors these softhearted spirits – sun filtering through the trees, a lazy bumblebee crossing their path, snow falling around them – and this enthusiasm translates to their learning as well. The innumerable possibilities swirling in their heads make them excited to learn about anything and everything. However, while idealism is perhaps their best trait, it can also, ironically, limit them the most.

One can look to Mediators' initial excitement over learning a new subject. They feel the inspiration, then overthink it, and talk themselves out of it before they even try. Barriers to concrete action affect these types disproportionately.

This is more about the sheer scale of any given interest making it so that they have no starting point. Mediators are masters of *correlation* – they see that everything fits together – but are not always equally good at *causation* – understanding where things start and end. Taking such a clear starting action is uncharacteristic, even if the lack of follow-through is.

Indulgent Learning

Learning is something that's innately valuable and should feel joyous. Mediators should indulge in learning what brings them joy and recognize that learning itself is an expression of joy. However, just as the saying goes, there can be "too much of a good thing."

When interest in a subject is absent, Mediators may feel incapable of sitting through it. They might justify not taking the time to learn and instead focus only on the topics that interest them. This complete

investment in interests, especially if they don't coincide with skills necessary for life, can be detrimental.

Focusing only on what they want, rather than what they need, can lead to huge knowledge deficits that later reveal themselves in their professional development. If they never learn the technical basics of writing, for instance, they'll struggle in their writing careers despite their inherent talent.

Rebalancing Lifelong Learning

Research and Idealism

While research isn't Mediators' forte, it's sure to save them a lot of grief (and money) in the long run. These types, though Introverted, can also be more impulsive and indulgent with their learning and prefer ideation over implementation. Being aware of this trait, students with a balanced approach to learning temper their idealism with research to preserve their most precious resource – time.

They can use their Prospecting trait to lead them to topics that they find engaging and interesting, but before they invest themselves wholeheartedly into these subjects, they can first do in-depth research to unmake their bad habit of readily committing with little context.

Here's an exercise that mixes their research and idealism and can give them a realistic peek at adding a potential new course to their schedule:

- Consider the options:
  - Location and time of the course: Can they make it on time? Do they face any significant scheduling conflicts?
  - Instructor: Are they well regarded? Strict, lax? Look up online ratings and ask peers.
  - Price: Can they afford the extra cost? Are there community-driven alternatives to community college or university courses?
  - Make sure that it fits their schedule. Ask, "Am I overcommitting myself by adding this to my schedule? Do I have enough time and resources to wholeheartedly engage in the course?"

- Look for outside opinions:
  - Look up course and instructor reviews on the Internet.
  - Ask friends if they've studied the same subject and how it suited them.
  - Contact the instructor of the course. Many instructors hold open office hours, and a conversation can reveal whether the course is a good fit.

The information gathered can help Mediators decide whether the new course fits into their schedule. Exhaustive consideration prevents these types from committing long term to an incompatible interest.

A Creative Plan

Sitting down and analyzing the basics can be difficult for all Intuitive types, but even more so for Mediators, who are notorious daydreamers. Their wonderful minds conjure up grand stories, but once their dreams are over, they may be left with a huge gap between where they are and what they imagined. They may begin with Step "A," and their Intuitive minds skip over "B," "C," "D," and all the way to "Z" – at which point they may have no idea where to start. But some students have learned to erase this confusion by going back and building a well-researched timeline that begins with learning the fundamentals of the subject that they want to pursue.

Planning can add some structure to Mediators' often vague lifelong goals. By developing a loose plan that incorporates their values and desires, they can saunter forward with confidence rather than confusion. The following exercise can help clarify things:

- Take the time to visualize what brings happiness – not what society says brings happiness, but what your own experience tells you.
- What is a goal that can be achieved a week from now?
  - Remember to start small – when planning for the future, even tiny changes can add up to big commitments.
- What are the benefits of achieving this goal?
- List out 10 steps to take to achieve this goal.

Mediators should take their time to write out their ideal vision statement and tailor it to their lifelong learning desires. It's easy to begin! Start the exercise in the morning, and look at the results at the end of the day. This is an easy exercise to repeat, and growing Mediators often find themselves surprised at the changes they see from day to day.

Conclusion

Life Is Learning

For Mediators, education is a way to move closer to the world and people around them. But it can be so much more for those willing to take a chance. The challenge for these types isn't so much in the hard work of learning – the challenge is managing their imaginations and finding a reasonable footing so that education is a rewarding experience. For Mediators, balancing their passion and soft hearts with practical and realistic expectations is quite achievable and even more satisfying.

They can achieve this balance by taking time for setting plausible expectations for themselves, taking time to find meaning and merit in the mundane, understanding that an A+ doesn't equate to self-worth, and allowing themselves room to be wrong, as well as celebrating their accomplishments and failures in equal turn.

In the end, it's important to note that balance and imbalance are states, and neither state lasts forever. All of us, as a collective, go back and forth. Like the seasons, balance comes and goes. The trees grow taller and stronger and people grow smarter and wiser, all of us advancing in our way. As we make progress, we come to knowing those seasons.

Professional Development

Rare, complex, and enigmatic, Mediators seek careers that are more than just jobs. Whatever their profession, they need a role that enables them to support worthy causes and exercise creative freedom. This combination motivates them to make great contributions and do their best work.

Throughout this section, we'll discuss how Mediators can maintain balance, excel in their professional development, identify the factors that may frustrate that development, and learn how they can utilize their strengths to regain their balance and thrive in their careers. Ultimately, we hope that this guide offers the understanding and tools to help Mediators find professional fulfillment.

Putting Idealism to Work

Some people strive for materialistic or egoistic goals – a salary, title, number of subordinates, or impressive degree. Mediators, however, want to do something meaningful and help others. To put this idealism to work, they must find roles that suit them.

Mediators often find the greatest happiness when they dare to explore their interests rather than settle for a typical path. Although doing so may require trial and error – and, at times, great effort – the journey is certainly worthwhile. Following their instincts while still challenging themselves to do their best work can help Mediators grow both professionally and personally.

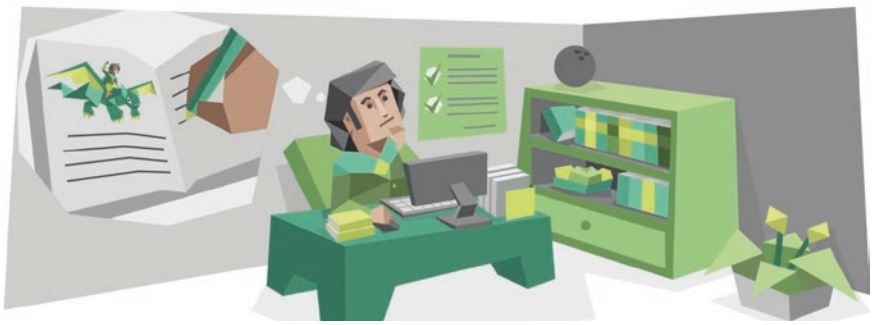
Restless Hearts

Mediators like to feel that their actions have purpose, and they aim to foster harmony, understanding, and connection. Unfortunately, those qualities aren't often the currency of the world of business. Common career paths may not fulfill Mediators, leaving them feeling isolated, restless, or unsatisfied.

Although they're capable of great dedication when inspired, Mediators usually dislike routine tasks, strictly impersonal work, and analysis of minor details, so they may not thrive in careers that focus on data rather than people. To be happy, people with this personality type usually need creative roles. But, with inspiration, even the most data-driven or technical field can be pursued as an art, whether coding a video game or riveting an airplane.

Despite their longing for human connection, their Introversion means that they can be exhausted by prolonged contact with others. People with this personality type need to be on their own occasionally – if that doesn't happen at work, stress can build. Some jobs, such as most sales and customer service positions, require that employees be "on" throughout their shifts. These jobs can be exhausting – though potentially still fulfilling – for Mediators.

Suitable Careers for Mediators



Professional development takes place across all stages of life, from early education through retirement, and it's interwoven with personal development as well. Gaining increased self-understanding – by determining values, goals, strengths, and weaknesses – is essential. In this section, we'll help Mediators gain a deeper understanding of the role that personality type plays in choosing a suitable career.

What follows isn't a firm prescription as to what Mediators must do to be successful or happy. Rather, we hope it provides some decision-making insight. Perhaps the most important question for Mediators to ask when searching for a career isn't "What do I want to be?" but rather "Who do I want to be?"

Creative Arts

It can be difficult to turn artistic talent into a paycheck. Fortunately, Mediators who pursue creative careers needn't be starving artists. As freelancers or employees within a larger corporate structure, such as a staff writer at a magazine or a commercial artist at a brand-strategy firm, they can earn a solid and sustainable living. Almost any subject imaginable has an accompanying publication, and a knowledgeable Mediator might be the best candidate for their creative direction.

The world isn't always as nonhierarchical as Mediators would like, and they may find that specific training or education facilitates their entry into artistic fields. For careers such as architecture, the right credentials and degrees can open doors, allowing Mediators to conceive and execute truly grand, creative masterpieces. Similarly, formal training in programming may help Mediators find work in web design, video game design, or even certain types of multimedia production.

If Mediators struggle to balance financial demands with their creative impulses, they have the option of pursuing their passions as side projects. Thanks to technology, reaching a wider audience no longer requires a full-time career in the arts. In their free time, Mediators can experiment with self-publishing their fiction, sharing their films on streaming video services, selling crafts through social media markets... the possibilities grow with each passing year.

Of course, in-person connections also help. To maintain their motivation, Mediators may benefit from connecting with other artists in their communities, sharing time and inspiration with them. Taking classes is a great way to find other people who care about making art.

Here are a few careers well suited to the Mediator personality type:

- Artist: fine artist, commercial artist, graphic designer, photographer, illustrator, sculptor

- Musician: songwriter, composer, producer, performer
- Crafts: fiber artist, pattern designer, woodworker
- Architect
- Writer: novelist, editor, essayist, copywriter

Health Care

Positions in health and wellness leverage Mediators' empathy, giving them a sense of purpose and enabling them to make a difference. Whether they specialize in mental or physical health, Mediators can help others gain insight into their behaviors, achieve self-discovery, and improve their well-being. An ideal position also allows Mediators to exercise their creativity to help their clients feel better. Certain health care jobs also suit Mediators' Introverted natures, such as those that allow them to serve patients individually, with time between clients to reflect on the experience.

Health care positions that may suit Mediators include:

- Medicine: physician, nurse or nurse practitioner, school nurse, physician's assistant, midwife or doula, physical therapist, dentist or dental assistant, optometrist, paramedic, dietician, health coach, massage therapist, veterinarian or veterinary assistant
- Counseling: therapist, addiction counselor, marriage counselor, psychiatrist (with emphasis on psychotherapy), psychologist, child or developmental psychologist, school psychologist, licensed clinical social worker
- Alternative health: practitioner of acupuncture, traditional Chinese medicine, Ayurveda, sound healing, Reiki, the Alexander Technique, the Feldenkrais Method, Emotional Freedom Technique, etc.; herbalist; yoga or meditation teacher; breath-work teacher

Education

Mediators are well suited to teaching and working with students. They connect with younger students through imagination, intuition, and empathy. With older students, they present topics with passion and creativity, especially when teaching the humanities.

Regardless of whom they teach, Mediators treat their students as individuals with specific traits and needs. They look beyond test scores and conventional metrics of success, glimpsing the unique potential of each student. Although Mediators may find constant contact with students and colleagues throughout the day taxing, they nevertheless enjoy the sense that they're changing lives for the better.

In addition to roles as teachers or professors, Mediators might consider other education-related careers such as guidance counselor, school nurse, school psychologist, or even sports coach. Depending on their personal religious beliefs, Mediators also make excellent religious instructors and leaders, sharing their compassion and love for humanity within their belief system.

Some educational roles that may fit Mediators' skills and preferences:

- Preschool, elementary, or high school teacher
- College lecturer (especially in religion, philosophy, or literature)
- Adult education teacher
- Guidance counselor
- Sports coach
- Religious educator

Public Service and Social Work

Thanks to their ethical standards and caring natures, many Mediators are drawn to public service and social work. Despite their acute sensitivity, their desire to serve others gives them the strength to face tragic and painful situations. They can support, comfort, and advocate for those in need through a variety of roles. Any administrative tedium can be balanced by Mediators' love of directly talking to, comforting, and helping people in need.

Of course, public service isn't limited to office jobs. Some Mediators feel called to do environmental work, such as nature conservation and restoration or positions within the public, state, or federal parks system. Such roles offer opportunities for outdoor solitude as well as personal contribution – a combination that appeals to many Mediators.

Specific public service jobs that Mediators might enjoy include:

- Social worker: specializations include community, health care, family, or military
- Nonprofit employee or director
- Librarian
- Community organizer
- Outdoors: conservationist, park ranger, environmental researcher, landscape architect, forester, wildlife researcher, marine biologist, geoscientist, oceanographer

Service Industry

For Mediators, making a difference in someone's life – or even just their day – is deeply gratifying. Provided they find environments that allow meaningful interactions with customers, Mediators can thrive in retail or service businesses. By offering personalized recommendations and truly listening to customers, people with this personality type can cultivate a loyal, appreciative clientele.

Beyond the constant opportunities to help people, lower-pressure service jobs can offer the flexibility to continue their education or pursue personal goals in their free time. Such roles can even prepare entrepreneurial Mediators to open their own independent businesses. For those who enjoy it, the service industry can be a long-term career fit. From luxury hotels to fine restaurants, some high-end businesses offer surprisingly generous compensation to experienced employees, particularly in cities and travel hubs.

That said, it's important for Mediators to find employers whose missions and cultures resonate with them. People with this personality type require jobs that align with their values and allow them to be their authentic selves.

Some positions in the service industry that may be a good fit:

- Food service: restaurant host, server, or manager; barista; bartender; sommelier

- Hospitality: hotel employee or manager, bed-and-breakfast owner, vacation rental host
- Retail store associate or manager
- Tour guide

Career Alternatives

We live in an age of possibilities, and selling one's time to a corporation isn't the only way to earn money. Mediators are imaginative individuals, and their ability to make connections between seemingly unrelated things and ideas can be very valuable beyond the realm of conventional employment.

Self-Employment

Many people find the notion of self-employment quite scary, but the working world has changed radically and job security is less of a guarantee even with stable, large employers. On the plus side, self-employment comes with a range of benefits, such as the ability to plan one's time, direct oneself, and see the tangible results of work done. Mediators enjoy independence and creative latitude, and being self-employed provides both – whether as freelance writers, graphic designers, tutors, coaches, consultants, or something else entirely.

Unfortunately, starting a business without a solid plan can lead to frustration, heartache, and an empty wallet. Mediators have a strong aversion to the pressures of salesmanship, but finding a worthwhile cause and turning it into an ethical business idea can be incredibly rewarding, both financially and morally – enough to justify a little risk and stress. The keys to success include good ideas that speak to others and strong relationships with vendors and clients. Mediators' human insight and vibrant imaginations serve them well in these areas.

If considering the path of self-employment, Mediators must be willing to experiment, work hard, and fail along the way. Success is far from guaranteed, and at times the demands of going solo may stretch them beyond their comfort zones. Fortunately, self-employment grants Mediators the independence to follow their passions, and their natural charisma reflects well on whatever service or product they offer.

Professional Volunteerism

Those who devote themselves entirely to pursuing matters of conscience and progress can move mountains. Although unlikely to lead to financial prosperity, the path of volunteerism can offer unparalleled personal satisfaction and growth. Early on, such efforts may have to be supported by minor income from other endeavors, but Mediators may also transition into volunteerism later in life, offering wisdom and vigor as well as skill sets from previous occupations.

Regardless of their background, experienced and educated Mediators can find ways to apply their abilities and knowledge to worthy causes, especially if they're willing to travel. From welders and carpenters to teachers and doctors, any skill set can be useful in the right environment. Mediators can establish small volunteer groups or even act individually. For example, almost anyone with warmth, patience, and a high school education can contribute by tutoring children in reading and math, and doing so can make an incredible difference in the youngsters' futures.

By following the path of volunteerism, Mediators can satisfy their desire to create harmony and healing in the world. They can dip their toe in while keeping a day job or plunge into the deep end and devote their time entirely to helping others.

Workplace Roles

Many Mediators enjoy working without any sort of hierarchy or leadership structure, at a level neither above nor below anyone else. Directly interacting with the people and ideas that are relevant to what they're trying to accomplish is the dream for these types. That said, Mediators do sometimes need to step into leadership roles or positions of authority to transform their visions into reality – and for these types, that transition to leadership can represent a monumental challenge. Fortunately, Mediators are creative and inspired people – under the right conditions, most any position can work.

Mediators as Subordinates

Balanced Subordinate Behavior

Infectious Positivity

Managers who recognize excellence and correct errors gently can expect strong commitment and cheerfulness from Mediator employees. If Mediators believe in their work, they throw their hearts into it. Praise from managers and coworkers reinforces their enthusiasm and delight, cementing their natural positivity into lasting loyalty.

When they feel appreciated, Mediators find additional ways to be helpful around the workplace, whether by chipping in on an additional project or by developing a plan to tackle a longstanding problem. In validating environments, they're more likely to speak up in group settings and offer their insights. Even better, their positive energy is infectious, brightening the workday for their peers – and often their managers as well.

Helpful Accountability

Mediators can most easily leverage their strengths when given sufficient time and space. They don't like time crunches or tight deadlines, preferring instead to consider and review their work. Many Mediators have a perfectionist streak – given the opportunity, they take as much time as possible to assess and revise their ideas and efforts before inviting outside scrutiny – a trait that garners them a reputation for being insightful and reflective.

However, some jobs – particularly subordinate roles – don't offer this latitude, which means that self-aware Mediators must find strategies to work efficiently. Although it goes against their independent natures, they may need outside support to avoid procrastination and stick to deadlines. They might create accountability by asking a manager or a colleague for regular check-ins, allowing them to track their progress – or lack thereof – rather than ignore it. Counter to their own intuitions, Mediators often find that strict deadlines help them by forcing them to break their habit of passive idealism and perfectionism. Over time, people with this personality type can ease into doing work that's "good enough," rather than holding out for perfection.

Unbalanced Subordinate Behavior

Hypersensitive to Criticism

Although they want to grow, Mediators are highly sensitive to conflict and criticism. Often suffering from fragile confidence, they're vulnerable to becoming hurt and confused when people disagree with them, dislike them, or are unkind. In the workplace, even minor corrections or negative feedback – from coworkers, clients, and especially managers – can take the wind right out of their sails.

When conflict or criticism is aimed at them personally, they lose their objective negotiating skills. They're at risk for becoming social loners if they don't find kindred spirits, or at least respectful peers, in the workplace. Emotionally marginalized Mediators may withdraw like hermits, viewing the outside world and other people with anything ranging from wavering wistfulness to reserved resentment.

To cope with workplace critics, these types may find themselves acting in a host of unproductive ways. They might amplify the self-critical voice in their heads, aiming to anticipate every possible rebuke that might be launched their way – a surefire recipe for perfectionism, procrastination, burnout, or worse. Or they might shut down, shying away from new challenges and avoiding people who've criticized them in the past. Unfortunately, such reactions prevent Mediators from distinguishing between helpful and unhelpful feedback, adjusting their course accordingly, and making their full impact in the world.

Disillusionment

Principled and idealistic, Mediators need to feel good about the culture of their work environment. To them, the moral and emotional foundation of any pursuit matters more than quantitative returns. When managers prioritize profits and pecking orders while disregarding morale and fairness, Mediators can turn from whistling workers into disgruntled detractors.

Ideally, they can transform this disillusionment into positive action, either by advocating for reform or by seeking a better work environment, but if they allow themselves to feel helpless, their disappointment with management simply saps their motivation. Mediators can numb out by

dragging their heels on tasks, withdrawing from people or projects they disagree with, or wasting precious energy bemoaning the situation rather than working to change it. This dynamic is doubly destructive as it not only prevents Mediators from doing their best work but also damages their sense of personal integrity.

Rebalancing Subordinate Behavior

Reassessing Praise and Criticism

Many Mediators are tempted to avoid criticism and pursue praise. This can lead to imbalances in their skill sets, robbing them of opportunities to bolster their weaknesses, benefit from constructive feedback, and understand their true goals for their work, independent of other people's opinions. All too often, this approach prevents them from tackling the grand challenges that result in lasting change.

To escape this trap, Mediators must learn to balance their inner wisdom with feedback from managers, colleagues, and clients. They can do this by reminding themselves that other people's opinions provide valuable information – about the *opinion giver*, not only the person being judged. If a manager criticizes them for writing long emails, that may simply mean that the manager prefers concise communications. A different manager might appreciate the thought and nuance that go into longer messages.

On the flipside, if they're praised for making a big sale, that doesn't necessarily mean that they should work as a salesperson. The key is for Mediators to *respond* rather than react to feedback by reflecting on its motivation, value, and potential helpfulness before absorbing or deflecting it.

Here are some ways that Mediators can adjust their reception to feedback:

- Rather than accepting managers' opinions as fact (or dismissing them out of hand), insert them into the following formula: "My managers believe [insert opinion]. This teaches me that they would prefer [insert corollary preference]."

  - Example: My managers believe that decisions should be made based on statistics rather than emotions. This teaches me that they would prefer that I ground my suggestions in data.

- Decide whether to honor the corollary preference. In the example above, this can be done by bolstering all suggestions with data going forward.

- If the managers' preferences or opinions seem out of line, approach the situation as if a miscommunication has occurred. Broach the matter directly with managers. It may not be easy, but an honest discussion clears the air and eliminates any false assumptions. (Mediators' diplomatic skills serve them well in such sensitive conversations.)

- When faced with constructive feedback, look for ways to grow – and develop a plan to pursue them.

By steering themselves away from assumptions and remembering not to take criticism as a personal attack, Mediators can choose *how* to respond to feedback rather than reacting on instinct. Integrating helpful critiques and leaving the rest behind equips these types to steer by their internal compass.

Quashing Helplessness

When managers violate their principles, Mediators lose motivation. They might isolate themselves from colleagues or perform their tasks halfheartedly, no longer bringing their typical creativity and optimism to their work. Over time, this can lead to underperformance, which is likely to erode Mediators' self-esteem and sense of purpose.

The culprit in this situation is helplessness – an emotion that clashes with Mediators' hopeful, idealistic spirit. To cope, they can brainstorm concrete ways to improve their work environment and then follow through with action. Steps can be large or small, from bringing in baked goods or leaving nice hand soap in the bathroom to chatting with coworkers who are struggling.

Mediator subordinates can also stand up for their principles in ways that are available to them. The following ideas can empower Mediators to do this:

- Before suggesting changes, consider what changes are desired and why. When presenting any change in policy or idea for improvement, take stock of existing resources. Knowing what policies already exist can further emphasize the benefit of new ideas.
- Note the reasoning, including the pros and, when they're obvious, cons of the plan. Even a plan with drawbacks can yield overall improvement – and sometimes more feedback can eliminate or minimize flaws.
- Approach a respected colleague for feedback. A second perspective can spot hidden flaws in the plan as well as opportunities.
- Practice presenting the ideas before meeting with a manager. Schedule enough time to ensure the entire idea can be presented as well as any questions answered.
- Offer to take responsibility for implementing the idea. Trust the vision enough to make it a reality.

Even without managerial authority, Mediators can be beacons in their workplaces, ushering positive change and brightening their own experiences as well as those of their colleagues.

Mediators as Colleagues

Balanced Colleague Behavior

Goodwill and Empathy

Mediators' empathy and sensitivity can be a balm to coworkers. Always offering gentle support, friendship, and a helpful attitude, they add warmth and human understanding to nearly every aspect of their workday, setting up themselves and everyone around them for success. Regardless of where they fall on the career ladder, they model kindness and consideration, inspiring others with their sincere efforts.

Their goodwill is more than a morale booster – it can increase productivity. Although they do well independently, Mediators are

wonderful team players, thinking less about their own acclaim than about how they can elevate and energize the team. When they allow themselves to fully develop this quality, they can increase a team's productivity by encouraging harmonious cooperation, staving off conflict, and fostering true team spirit.

Unbalanced Colleague Behavior

Naïveté

Mediators' positivity charms many people, breathing fresh life into stale workplaces. That said, this trait may cause blunt or cynical coworkers to judge them as naïve. Hard-edged colleagues often roll their eyes at Mediators' tendency to assume that every problem is solvable and that everyone is well intentioned.

When faced with workplace conflict, Mediators may put their trademark positivity into overdrive, refusing to take sides or even acknowledge tension. Such situations make people with this personality type deeply uncomfortable, and their desire to remain friendly with everyone may alienate them from frank, straight-shooting colleagues. As a result, Mediators may end up accidentally at odds with people they haven't wronged simply by refusing to speak up about a situation.

No Solitary Time

Despite their need for solitary time, people with this personality type may struggle to withdraw to be on their own. This phenomenon becomes particularly pronounced if coworkers or clients keep requesting their help, which is common because many Mediators struggle to establish boundaries around their time and space when they feel that people need them. This consideration for others may seem beneficial, but in the long run it sticks Mediators in "survival mode."

Solitude is essential for these types to refill the fonts of energy and empathy that fuel them to be such powerful agents of positive change. When they force themselves to be in constant contact with others, Mediators' morale suffers, leading them to exhibit uncharacteristic negativity, which can dampen their colleagues' spirits as well. Unless they manage to carve out pockets of alone time, Mediators won't do

their best work. Quiet reflection typically enables them to generate their best ideas – without it, they can feel uninspired, unmotivated, or simply down.

Rebalancing Colleague Behavior

Facing Conflict

Although Mediators might wish for drama-free lives, the reality is that all workplaces break into conflict occasionally. When this happens, they may struggle to identify the source of the tension, leading them to "take everyone's side." However, in some situations they must face conflicts head on and take sides.

When faced with workplace drama, the first question Mediators must ask themselves is: "Is this any of my business?" If the situation involves one of their own projects, a close colleague, or a clear ethical infraction, then they probably need to get involved – whether by helping to remedy the situation or by weighing in with their professional opinions.

If the situation doesn't involve their work or their close colleagues, Mediators may do well to curtail their instinct to help – otherwise, they may be viewed as meddling, particularly if they don't have the authority to put their natural diplomacy and people skills to full use. Here are some ways that Mediators can refrain from involving themselves unnecessarily:

- When workplace conflict arises, pause to reflect: "Would the situation benefit from my involvement?"
- If the answer is yes, consider your response. If someone pushes for a snap judgment in a nonemergency, then reply, "I need time to find out what's going on first."
- If the answer is no, don't step into the conflict unless asked. However well intended, such efforts can backfire.
- Speak to a trusted colleague and ask what's going on, especially about the origin of the tension. Nebulous, unbounded conflict can trigger catastrophizing among Mediators, so gaining a clear awareness of the situation may help mitigate stress.

- Manage your own resulting stress, if necessary. Take deep, slow breaths; listen to a guided meditation, such as progressive muscle relaxation or *yoga nidra*; or set aside some alone time.

Rather than rushing to involve themselves, Mediators can evaluate conflicts and then decide how to respond. By doing so, they maximize their chances of making a positive impact – whether that means helping to resolve an argument or simply keeping their heads down to focus on their own projects.

Creating Alone Time

Without pockets of alone time, Mediators tend to burn out. As much as they might enjoy helping and listening to others, they need to retreat from time to time to restore their energy, inspiration, and sense of capability. Otherwise, their satisfaction with their jobs – and themselves – gradually wanes, as does their confidence that they can make a difference.

For the many workers who lack private offices, taking alone time poses a challenge. Fortunately, Mediators excel at finding creative solutions. Those in sales or retail might approach their managers with requests to take on solo tasks, step out for solitary lunches, or start their workdays before others arrive. From time to time, Mediators in noisy, open-plan offices can put on headphones. This not only tunes out other people's conversations but also broadcasts that they're trying to focus, minimizing the likelihood of social distractions.

To gracefully withdraw from unmanageable workplace environs, Mediators can employ any of the following:

- Pay attention to your personal tolerance level for sustained social interaction. Some people go for hours without becoming depleted, whereas others can manage less, and certain activities, such as group meetings or watercooler chat, drain more. By knowing how you respond to such situations, you can anticipate when you'll need a break.
- Devise a list of ways to take alone time at work: wearing headphones, walking around the block, eating lunch alone, switching to a task that requires less social interaction, retreating to a bathroom stall for a few minutes, etc.

- Take a few deep breaths while counting down from 10, and relax into the present moment. This can help minimize the stress response even during prolonged social exposure.
- Take on more independent tasks. Brainstorm a list of tasks in advance and approach your supervisor, and come with a willingness to negotiate so that you get what you want. Or, approach colleagues with offers to take on or trade tasks.

Many Mediators adapt creatively to social workplaces by carving out pockets of solo time. As a result, these types can excel in a range of fields, even those that require significant interaction with others.

Mediators as Managers

Balanced Manager Behavior

Egalitarian Leaders

Unsurprisingly, Mediators don't impose their will on the people they manage. Instead, their cooperative tendencies lead them to solicit the opinions of their employees, creating an egalitarian and democratic work environment. Unlike micromanagers, Mediators give the people who work for them plenty of space to innovate and experiment, and they encourage creative thinking over strict adherence to protocols and deadlines.

Because Mediator managers view their employees' potential as more important than their pay grades, their team members' talents are used rather than left to languish. This fosters a nonhierarchical workplace where even junior staff members can make suggestions, exercise their judgment, and receive credit for their contributions. The result is that Mediators – despite their general reluctance to exercise authority – often bring out the best in the people they manage, encouraging them to grow and develop both personally and professionally.

Cultivating Talent

As managers, Mediators are open-minded, respectful, and always willing to offer support. Aiming to act as mentors rather than rule as dictators, they get to know their employees as individuals, learning the strengths and abilities that each person brings to the table. As a

result, they excel at cultivating talent, allowing their mentees to grow into capable allies.

Trusting the talent of their employees, Mediator managers often delegate responsibility. They're comfortable sharing their power and discretion with people who have earned their respect and trust. Mediators also encourage the people they manage to put their own spin on projects, valuing their employees' creativity, spontaneity, and unique perspectives above adherence to predetermined standards or procedures.

Unbalanced Manager Behavior

Letting It Slide

Although Mediators have high expectations for themselves, they don't always apply the same expectations to others. People with this personality type are averse to conflict and reluctant to criticize, and they tend to see the best in other people. If left unchecked, these traits can lead them to overlook bad behavior in their employees, prioritizing their relationships with team members above the success of the team.

As a result, Mediators can be too lenient even when genuine incompetence surfaces – a situation that ultimately damages team morale. It's fine for them to give their employees the benefit of the doubt, but they should try not to ignore poor performance or bad behavior. When they don't uphold standards, Mediators not only diminish their teams' chances of success but also de-motivate the employees who hold themselves to a higher standard.

Pressure Cooker

Mediators don't often seek out leadership positions, in part because the burden of managerial responsibility weighs heavily on their shoulders. Unfortunately, the pressures of command can get to them, especially in high-profile or particularly visible positions. If they don't keep their inner perfectionism in check, Mediators may overreact to stressful situations, lose their cool in crises, or overthink every decision.

Such tendencies can affect their ability to lead. Because they so desperately want to do things right, Mediator managers may delay important decisions, allowing themselves to get distracted by other priorities. As a result, they may find themselves either becoming paralyzed by indecision or making impulsive choices – neither of which ultimately benefits their workforce.

When they or their teams don't succeed, Mediator managers may criticize themselves harshly, feeling that they've let others down. Their powerful imagination might envision scenario after scenario of future failures, leaving them reluctant to maintain their managerial responsibilities. In the absence of firm encouragement and guidance from colleagues – which may be difficult to find at the managerial level – the pitfalls of a typical workplace can leave Mediators feeling lost, stressed out, or even depressed.

Rebalancing Manager Behavior

Establishing Expectations

Mediator managers don't have to refashion themselves into tyrants to set expectations for their employees. In fact, their positive natures can work in their favor when it comes to communicating new, higher standards. Although other personality types might use criticism to spur on employees, this strategy can be incredibly discouraging.

The Gallup Leadership Institute has found that teams perform best when their managers think that they're capable of great things. Mediators can leverage this phenomenon – known as self-fulfilling prophecy – by communicating the potential that they see in each of their employees and praising people for doing things right. They might even encourage their teams to take on "moonshot" projects that bring them to the edge of their abilities in pursuit of grand challenges.

That said, even smaller suggestions can lead to self-fulfilling prophecy. Whether their aim is improved sales or better workplace conduct, Mediator managers can explain themselves in positive terms – for example, "improved productivity" as opposed to "reduced distractions."

To reinforce positive self-image among their employees, they can also conclude discussions by explaining to their subordinates that they're fully capable of creating change. Here are some ways that they can productively frame feedback:

- Comment on team members' strengths and talents, highlighting each person's capacity to grow into their potential.
- Praise employees for their effort and their improvement.
- Suggest "moonshot" projects that encourage employees to push in new directions.
- Use positive language to communicate new expectations.
- Emphasize to employees that they can achieve what is being asked of them.

Positive reinforcement can help Mediator managers encourage their teams to perform to higher standards – without shaming them for past failures or slipups.

Pressure Relief

When faced with crises, impossible deadlines, and past failures, Mediator managers may feel helpless and overwhelmed. No matter how much they doubt their abilities, they're often more than capable of rising to such challenges. To do so, however, they need to take off some of the pressure they place on themselves. Although they might think that their inner critics motivate them to improve themselves, Mediators are more effective leaders and change agents when they embrace a balanced view of their abilities.

To keep perfectionism from undermining their leadership skills, Mediators must set realistic goals, enjoy their successes, and curb procrastination. Although they may want to achieve great things – such as turning around a company's culture or providing millions of people with access to clean water – Mediators can become overwhelmed and distracted unless they establish smaller, shorter-term objectives. When they or their teams do achieve their objectives, they should take a moment to acknowledge each success, reminding themselves of their essential capability.

Mediator managers must take note when they lapse into procrastination – whether putting off tasks or postponing decisions. They can enlist a more decisive or proactive colleague to help them move forward rather than stall out. As this tendency to delay action can escalate quickly, consider these tactics:

- Within the scope of larger visions, establish achievable, shorter-term objectives. If you normally think in years, consider goals for the next day or the next week.
- Celebrate progress, no matter how incremental. Whether with a team dinner, an office announcement, a calendar entry, or even a private journal entry, it's important to counterbalance memories of past failures – which tend to dominate our minds, thanks to a phenomenon known as negativity bias – with awareness of successes and accomplishments.
- Recognize procrastination when it arises. For many Mediators, a dead giveaway is physical uneasiness or a sense of being scattered or dissatisfied. Enlist support, ideally from an action-oriented colleague, to maintain progress.

These actions create a cycle of progress, affirmation, and momentum. Even better: if they mitigate their stress levels by setting realistic goals and enjoying their successes, Mediators can feel less inclined to procrastinate in the first place.

Workplace Cooperation Between Types

Even when they don't share similar backgrounds or experiences, Mediators and their coworkers can forge a healthy and productive workplace relationship. The following sections explain how Mediators can use their strengths and counterbalance common sources of conflict to build meaningful work relationships with various personality types. As these types well know, conversations that include mutual understanding tend to be much more productive than those that proceed with assumptions or stubborn perspectives.

Mediator-Analyst Cooperation

Balanced Mediator-Analyst Cooperation

Kindred Insights

Both Mediators and Analysts prefer to advance the "big picture" rather than fiddle with mundane details of facilitation. Both absorb knowledge almost subconsciously and then incorporate it into a larger constellation of meaning, often connecting concepts in deep ways. Their similarity in style and shared love for the abstract give Mediators and Analysts ample opportunities to imaginatively combine their talents.

In the workplace, they excel at working together to generate new ideas, identify areas that need improvement, and depart from the status quo. Their pattern-recognition skills enable them to investigate the root causes of problems and detect unexpected relationships. Not only would they notice that their organization isn't gaining enough publicity but they might also recognize the origins of the problem in the way that their organization presents itself to the outside world. Together, these two types can steer companies in new directions, spotting avenues for growth and improvement that others may miss.

Compatible Differences

Mediators' values and deep empathy can provide necessary balance to Analysts' interest in optimization – and vice versa. Mediators can add to Analysts' perspective by emphasizing emotional elements and offering human insight. As a result, Mediators can infuse "soul" into any system that Analysts devise, ensuring that objectives aren't met at the cost of people's well-being.

Of course, an organization that values love, peace, and harmony sometimes needs a reality check to sustain its mission. Rational,

impartial analysis – something that doesn't necessarily come easily to Mediators – is often required for a project to succeed in the long run. They can rely on Analysts to provide a critical counterpoint to their potentially damaging optimism. If running an organization together is like captaining a ship, then Mediators can be entrusted to conceive the journey and Analysts can be relied upon to optimize the route.

Unbalanced Mediator-Analyst Cooperation

Hiding Hurt Feelings

To put it mildly, Analysts share their opinions freely, and they are less conflict-averse than Mediators. When Analyst colleagues disagree with them, even in minor or constructive ways, especially sensitive Mediators may interpret the comments as judgmental or unfair. This can hit Mediators hard, making them feel unappreciated or unwelcome in their workplaces.

Faced with blunt commentaries from Analysts, Mediators may disengage, avoiding their Analyst colleagues whenever possible. They may also hesitate to share their views and opinions, shy away from challenging projects, or struggle to maintain focus on their tasks. Because they don't interpret disagreement as a personal affront (and often even enjoy it), Analysts may not even realize that they're having such a strong detrimental effect on their Mediator colleagues.

Caring or Naïve?

When Mediators and Analysts don't respect each other's priorities, their working relationships can become tense and unbalanced. Mediators may become alarmed when Analysts make decisions based purely on logic and expediency rather than taking relationships and people's feelings into account. When Mediators voice their objections, they might find themselves labeled "naïve" or "soft."

Confident and ever rational, Analysts are likely to shoot down Mediators who advocate for kindness over logic, accusing them of emotional decision-making (as though it isn't a valid perspective) or even questioning their intelligence. Mediators may suffer such brusqueness quietly but feel deeply hurt. If they truly feel that their principles are

being violated, however, they may hit an emotional breaking point, unleashing uncharacteristic anger and frustration on their colleagues.

Rebalancing Mediator-Analyst Cooperation

Nothing Personal

As intelligent and insightful as they are, Analysts are notorious for being emotionally chilly, often unintentionally (but not always!). In many cases, they dispense with common cordiality in favor of efficient, to-the-point communication. It may seem to sensitive Mediators that Analysts are intentionally unfriendly, when their intent is efficiency.

Once Mediators realize that Analysts' behavior rarely indicates any actual negativity, they can lower their defenses and enjoy their relationships. Of course, "Don't take things personally" is easier said than done. Here are some strategies that can be helpful:

- Pay attention to personal beliefs and expectations about how people "should" act in the workplace – for example, "People should offer feedback gently and considerately."
- Notice the interpretations that underlie these expectations. Does it feel like a personal attack if someone cuts down an idea without acknowledging its merits? Does it feel as if they're trying to convey personal disdain rather than impersonal feedback?
- Pay attention to situations that trigger your expectations. In the moment, come up with alternative explanations, even if they seem unlikely. Could the person just be doing things the way that they think is best? Might their behavior reflect their personality and their life experience – rather than being a personal attack?

Many Analysts don't ascribe to common societal expectations, even those that seem "obvious." When Analysts seem rude, harsh, or inconsiderate, Mediators can generate alternative explanations rather than taking the behavior personally.

Direct Communication

As much as they might want to avoid difficult conversations, the best

way for Mediators to communicate with Analysts is directly. When they feel that communication is blocked or a misunderstanding has occurred, they can ask Analysts where the disconnect lies and how they might work together to prevent similar problems in the future.

Candor is important in this case – not only because Analysts respect it but also because they're less emotionally attuned than Mediators and may not be aware of the issue in the first place. By adopting a straightforward yet sincere approach, Mediators can gently – by Analyst standards – draw attention to any rifts and steer the conversation toward solutions.

Mediators can also facilitate communication by asking insightful questions. Analysts love to share their opinions, so by asking questions, Mediators can better understand their opinions without getting sidetracked into disagreement. In fact, this type of conversation may motivate Analysts to inquire about Mediators' opinions.

Analysts generally respect people who ask good questions and prompt interesting discussions, so a questions-based conversation may pique their curiosity about Mediators' alternative viewpoints and ideas. Here are some suggestions for facilitating communication:

- Cultivate genuine curiosity about the situation.
- Communicate directly yet sincerely – for example, "What would you identify as the best possible outcome for this project?" or "How do you think we can work better together in the future?"
- Ask thoughtful questions. Don't be afraid to dig deep. Analysts love follow-up questions that allow them to delve into the many layers of a situation.
- If Analysts ask questions in return, be honest and straightforward. Don't hesitate to share opinions, but don't be surprised if Analysts expect the opinions to be supported by facts, data, or theories. This is simply how their minds work.

Shying away from conflicts with Analysts is rarely productive. Although it isn't easy for them, Mediators can facilitate productive interactions with their Analyst colleagues by being direct and authentic rather than walking on eggshells or withdrawing altogether.

Mediator-Diplomat Cooperation

Balanced Mediator-Diplomat Cooperation

Visions and Ideas

Mediators and other Diplomats have the advantage of speaking the same "language" – they're visionaries focused on growth, humanity, and exploring ideas. Others may talk about the nuts and bolts of an organization, but these personality types talk to each other about creating harmony and growth in the workplace. Although they may appear overly idealistic to other types, they agree among themselves that progress is always possible.

Together, Mediators and other Diplomats can breathe fresh air into any workplace. They might brainstorm a plan to more fairly distribute time or labor, for example, or they might launch an initiative to donate a portion of proceeds to charity. Although they delight in the kindred spirits of their fellow Diplomats, their empathy and openness allows them to understand the value of different perspectives.

For example, Mediators might consult a Thinking or Judging type for help with logistics or implementation. When other types offer critical feedback, Mediators and Diplomats know instinctively how to support each other through the process – or support each other in their next effort, if their initial idea turns out to be truly untenable.

Finding Purpose

For Mediators and other Diplomats, work is most exciting when it is purposeful on a deep level. These two quickly target any injustice or unfairness in a business, and they may form strong alliances around such matters. Unwilling to sacrifice their values to turn a profit or meet a benchmark, they agree that a cold, calculated approach to work or

business is never the right path, particularly if it's conducted at the expense of people's feelings or well-being.

In balanced situations, these two augment their idealistic, principled perspectives by collaborating with other colleagues, even those who might be more utilitarian or analytical. Provided they remember the inherent fairness of respecting others' opinions, Mediators and Diplomats are poised to recognize the unique strengths that their coworkers bring to the table.

By bringing together different perspectives and styles of thinking, they can allow their purposeful ideas to reach fruition in a way that aligns with everyone's interests and takes advantage of everyone's abilities. This not only gets things done – an arena where Mediators and Diplomats may struggle on their own – but also fosters egalitarianism and meritocracy in their workplaces.

Unbalanced Mediator-Diplomat Cooperation

Diplomat Island

Mediators and Diplomats often delight in working together, recognizing each other as all-too-rare kindred spirits. They must take care, however, not to limit their interaction with colleagues who think differently – even those who think "conventionally." Otherwise, they put themselves at risk of becoming stuck in their own style of thinking, missing out on opportunities to challenge their opinions and expand their worldviews.

In business and in life, it's good to have varied personality types around to provide balance. With their focus on ideas instead of deadlines, Mediators and Diplomats who opt to work in a vacuum may generate grand ideas that go nowhere, or their inherent optimism may cause them to underestimate practical challenges. Unless they enlist – and listen to – other opinions, they may fail to effect the positive changes that mean so much to them.

Talk, Talk, Talk

When Diplomats sequester themselves from other viewpoints, they tend to focus on guiding principles, mission statements, and long-term

visions – at the expense of tactical plans. Inspirational discussions can be an important launching pad toward a better future, but without a concrete how-to strategy, idealistic discussion may lead to gridlock. Endless discussions do more harm than good, and these two types must be particularly careful not let inertia set in when the job calls for action.

This dynamic often manifests itself when Mediators and other Diplomats face tough decisions, such as axing failing projects or slashing budgets. These are difficult topics for Diplomats to analyze objectively, given their idealistic drive to search for solutions that benefit everyone – solutions that, in some cases, simply don't exist. Without reality checks from other personality types, these two may put off necessary decisions for too long, ultimately damaging their – and others' – prospects of success.

Rebalancing Mediator-Diplomat Cooperation

Second Opinions

Mediators and Diplomats may enjoy each other's company so much that they inadvertently become cliquish, excluding colleagues who think differently. These two are fiercely egalitarian in principle, but at times the joy of finding a kindred spirit can completely blind them to the ways that they wall off others. Not only does this make their coworkers feel unwelcome or unheard, it also robs Mediators and Diplomats of the opportunity to hear alternative perspectives. In many cases, outside perspectives are essential for progress as they offer an important counterbalance to Mediators' and Diplomats' dauntless optimism and big-picture worldview.

To correct for any imbalances, Mediators and Diplomats can solicit the opinions of other coworkers – even coworkers who might seem stodgy or pessimistic. To broaden the conversation, they can include other coworkers in brainstorming sessions, meetings, and even informal discussions. Mediators' natural desire to include and listen to others comes in handy here.

Mediators and Diplomats can also solicit others' opinions to loosen the reins on their self-imposed perfectionism. When they fall short or fail to deliver, these two may languish in self-blame to the point that they cannot move forward at all. Instead, they can use their natural empathy and compassion to support each other in acknowledging their weaknesses and asking for help from colleagues whose strengths provide counterbalance. It's perfectly fine to approach a colleague and say, "I'm struggling with this project. Would you mind looking over my work for blind spots or other issues?"

To solicit help from others, Mediators and other Diplomats can:

- Create a list of all colleagues who might be approached for help. Briefly note their strengths, such as troubleshooting, financial analysis, or neutral analysis of workplace politics.
- Approach those people one-on-one when help is needed with a specific issue.
- Explain that you'd like an opinion on something, and ask whether they have time to speak now or if a later time would be better. If approaching them in person is too daunting, set up a time over email or text message.
- Come armed with specific questions, such as, "Does this seem feasible to you?" and "What would you recommend?"
- Establish appropriate expectations. Make it clear that you are asking for an opinion, not directives, and that you may proceed differently.
- Take notes during the conversation. Afterward, look through your notes and circle action items. Schedule a time to implement the actions or integrate them into the current plan.
- Afterward, thank the person for their time. Follow up to let them know how you have implemented their advice, if appropriate.
- Remember that, however awkward it may feel to ask for help, people are generally flattered and intrigued when asked to give their opinions.

Everyone has something to contribute. By drawing others into the conversation, Mediators and Diplomats leverage the full diversity of their colleagues' strengths.

Slow It Down

Idealistic goals often benefit the workplace, but they must be crafted one piece at a time with focus and care, not just hope. Mediators and Diplomats can encourage each other to slow down just a little, even when they feel that success is guaranteed. Instead of leaping forward to an assumed outcome, they should take the time to assess and review each stage of a potential project. This enables them to use their imaginations to identify potential pitfalls as well as opportunities for improvement.

In meetings as well as informal discussions, Mediators and other Diplomat types can remind each other to devise action plans to back up their big ideas. Failing that, they can enlist other personality types who take a more hands-on approach: Sentinels and Explorers in particular can help Diplomats identify realistic, achievable steps in pursuit of any grand goal.

- After identifying a promising goal or idea, take a moment to assess it. How many people-hours would the project entail? What benchmarks would have to be met? Who would need to contribute, and what specific tasks would they handle? If you focused on this idea, what other projects or tasks *wouldn't* get done? Write out answers to these questions.
- Solicit opinions and advice from people with other thinking styles.
- Chart out each stage of the project, incorporating the insights received in the previous step. Specifically consider any potential issues that might arise. What adjustments can be made to preempt or address them? Do they make the idea unfeasible?

Without sacrificing their trademark optimism, Mediators and Diplomats can support each other to translate their big ideas into action steps and timelines. That way, they won't get derailed or distracted as they tackle the wonderful projects that they conceive together.

Mediator-Sentinel Cooperation

Balanced Mediator-Sentinel Cooperation

Human Interest

Both Mediators and Sentinels see the value of human connection in the workplace, albeit in different ways. Mediators' interest is more intuitive and ideological, whereas Sentinels focus on the practical groundwork necessary to forge and maintain relationships. For example, Mediators might quickly detect the mood of a potential client or customer. Upon hearing those insights, Sentinels can navigate the necessary steps to bolster the underlying relationship.

As a result, Mediators and Sentinels can excel at collaborating on matters that involve people, such as human resources, hiring, and even negotiations. With Mediators offering a high-level view of what is right, fair, or just, Sentinels can then tackle the on-the-ground practicalities necessary to structure benefit packages, collect references, or get a contract approved. When these two types communicate and cooperate fully, their differing strengths create a human-centric synergy that facilitates goodwill as well as progress.

Creativity Meets Diligence

Mediators and Sentinels complement each other by providing different kinds of support for an organization. For Mediators, the larger picture and big ideas are important. Directives that come across as strict or nitpicky may feel frustrating or needlessly harsh to them, so they sometimes miss small but essential details. Sentinels don't, and their diligence and guidance can complement Mediators' creativity to ensure that work runs smoothly and the organization prospers.

Mediators can help Sentinels tune into the intangible side of human interaction, and Sentinels can help Mediators stay on target when it comes to precision, productivity, and tough but necessary decisions. Sentinels can encourage and guide Mediators when practical focus is needed, helping them keep their feet on the ground while striding in the right direction. In a balanced relationship, Mediators recognize that Sentinels' insights – however nitpicky they might initially seem – will foster improvement and progress. As a result, Sentinels can motivate Mediators to stick with work that seems tedious to get things done.

Unbalanced Mediator-Sentinel Cooperation

Rules vs. Flexibility

Sentinels may place procedures and professional responsibility above other people's feelings, which can alienate and even hurt sensitive Mediators. When Mediators are tired, uninspired, or struggling, they consider it reasonable to take personal time and adjust expectations. However, Sentinels may well expect them to push through and get the job done anyway – an expectation Mediators might take personally, especially if they struggle with insecurity.

In such situations, Mediators might feel trapped. On one hand, they may believe that Sentinels are being unreasonable. On the other hand, it pains them to fall short in their colleagues' eyes. Typical workplace issues such as tardiness, precision, policy adherence, and follow-through can trigger this dynamic, with Sentinels insisting on strict accountability and Mediators struggling to juggle workplace performance with their life circumstances – an inherently stressful situation.

Good Enough?

Driven by idealism and grand visions, Mediators always strive toward improvement and a better future. Because Sentinels generally value and adhere to proven standards and methods, Mediators' dreams of different realities may exasperate them. Sentinels appreciate the status quo and are reluctant to fix things that aren't broken, especially when the bottom line is already adequately served.

As a result, these two may disagree about engaging with new ideas, whether a new social media strategy or a different way to arrange merchandise. When Sentinels disregard Mediators' visions for change, Mediators may interpret the feedback as a personal attack. In turn, Mediators may find themselves accused of wasting time or "messing with success" in their search for better ways to do things.

Rebalancing Mediator-Sentinel Cooperation

Reasons for Rules

Although practical strictures may stymie their optimism, Mediators can cultivate an appreciation for what might seem like nitpickiness in their Sentinel colleagues. In many cases, details matter immensely – sometimes someone must uphold rules and keep an eye on the bottom line. Instead of resenting Sentinels for their traits, Mediators can learn to value having help with things that aren't necessarily their strongest qualities.

When Mediators spot this silver lining, they should thank Sentinels for their efforts. Although they might not ask for praise, Sentinels work incredibly hard even in the face of personal challenges, and they're grateful when their dedication is acknowledged. A simple acknowledgment and word of thanks can help them maintain motivation or get through a difficult day.

Mediators can work most effectively with Sentinels by demonstrating – rather than talking about – cooperation and compromise. For Sentinels, actions truly speak louder than words. Here is a framework that can facilitate the process:

- Fully listen to and consider Sentinels' suggestions. Ask questions about their rationale and the results that they'd like to see.
- Implement – or at least experiment with – one of their suggestions. Approach the endeavor with an air of curiosity, open-mindedness, and discovery. The experiment can take many forms, such as conducting "AB" testing (comparing two ideas simultaneously) or piloting an idea for a specific amount of time.

- Track the results of the experiment, noting the full range of micro and macro benefits. Have budget cuts been avoided? Did a process go more smoothly than it usually does? Review your insights with colleagues – including Sentinels – and work together to decide how future scenarios might be handled.
- Thank Sentinels for their ideas and their contributions.

By experimenting with Sentinels' rules and noting the benefits, Mediators may come to recognize these colleagues as hardworking, principled allies, always willing to pitch in and help to move things forward.

Progress and Compromise

In tense working relationships, Mediators and Sentinels lock horns over new ideas. Because Sentinels often defend the status quo, Mediators are left to demonstrate the merits of the alternatives that they envision. However, because of their Intuitive and Prospecting traits, Mediators may have difficulty supporting their ideas with concrete, specific evidence – the type of evidence that would sway Sentinels.

There are several potential remedies to this situation. If Mediators don't have their Sentinel colleagues' trust, they may need to prove their ability to structure an effective plan – for example, by learning project management techniques or by creating SMART goals (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-Bound). These frameworks may help Sentinels feel confident that Mediators can balance their inherent idealism with an awareness of logistics and practicalities.

Mediators can also adopt the following approach to suggest changes to Sentinels:

- Review the current protocol thoroughly. Collect data on its performance, if available. List benefits and weaknesses.
- Outline the proposed alternative in concrete terms. What specific changes need to be made? Who will do the work? How long will the project take to reach fruition? What are its specific advantages? For example, will it bolster customer satisfaction or increase sales? How can its success be measured?

- Consider potential counterarguments to the new idea. Evaluate their validity and plan replies in advance.
- Meet in person with the Sentinel and present the above analysis. A written copy is helpful, as are charts (if relevant).
- Suggest changes as evolutions of the current procedure rather than a radical departure.
- Solicit feedback and take notes. Integrate the feedback into a revised version of the idea, if possible.

Mediator-Explorer Cooperation

Balanced Mediator-Explorer Cooperation

Always Improving

The common ground between Mediators and Explorers may be difficult to define, but it certainly exists. Both enjoy moving forward in life and striving for improvement, although their approaches are different. Whereas Mediators often approach challenges by considering large-scale ideas and implications, their Explorer colleagues excel at finding practical solutions to specific problems.

When it comes to workplace issues, these two can approach any issue from different angles to solve it complementarily. Mediators can offer creative vision, opening the doors for change and improvement. Explorers can then tackle problems that arise, explaining how to make things work – often in unique and exciting ways. Given their shared respect for flexibility and experimentation, these two types are powerful allies in pursuit of innovation.

Here and Now

When Mediators get lost in their mental chatter, they can count on Explorer colleagues to snap them out of it. Explorers find the exciting side of things, whether they're learning how to use a new tool or troubleshooting on the fly. As a result, Explorers can teach Mediators to set aside their worries – which are almost always about the future or the past – and encourage them to fully inhabit the present moment.

Working with Explorers offers Mediators a break from their minds and a chance to lose themselves in the work at hand – a respite that suits their Introverted and Intuitive natures. If they struggle with perfectionism, Mediators may frequently second-guess themselves in the workplace – losing their nerve, leaving tasks undone, and failing to act on their ideas. Given their delight in the here and now and their keen eye for novelty, Explorer colleagues can be a refreshing change for otherwise restrained Mediators. Their energy and vigor can reignite Mediators' motivation, helping them to follow through on their plans.

Unbalanced Mediator-Explorer Cooperation

Values vs. Utility

Although established standards don't bind either Mediators or Explorers as tightly as they might Sentinels, Mediators do live by a code. Their values are active forces in their lives, as real as any actions. Explorers have values of their own, but they focus more on utilitarian solutions than ideals, which influences the way that they handle business. For instance, Explorers might be relatively willing to fire underperforming employees or bolster sales by taking client lists from their competitors – two behaviors that would probably wound Mediators' sense of principle.

In discussing workplace plans and practices, Mediators may sometimes be concerned about Explorers' disregard for human consequences over goal achievement. This can build into a mutual resentment, with Mediators seeing Explorers as disregarding ethical standards and Explorers viewing Mediators as being downers who let nothing slide, leaving the two unable to cooperate at all.

Second-Guessing

If their worries outweigh their self-confidence, Mediators fall into the trap of overthinking everything and indulging in endless *what-ifs*. By contrast, Explorers like to move quickly into action. If Mediators get in Explorers' way, they may find themselves labeled "wet blankets." Although it sounds innocent enough, this criticism may be disheartening to Mediators, who view themselves as free spirits at heart. Faced with this type of feedback, Mediators may doubt their abilities, second-guess themselves even more, or shut down altogether.

Of course, these aren't ideal conditions for collaboration and cooperation. If Mediators retreat from their Explorer colleagues to escape judgment, they compromise the incredible potential these two have to cancel out each other's weaknesses. In addition, Mediators may carry their hurt feelings and self-doubt to other arenas of their lives, from their relationships to their passion projects.

Rebalancing Mediator-Explorer Cooperation

Calls to Action

Mediators may not agree with Explorers' utilitarianism – in other words, their prioritization of expediency and results no matter the consequences for other people – but that doesn't mean that they can't work together productively. In fact, open-minded Mediators are uniquely poised to appreciate Explorers' creativity (if it isn't too impulsive or outlandish). This appreciation can go a long way with Explorers, many of whom aim to achieve mastery in their work.

So how can Mediators work with Explorers in a way that leaves both parties feeling capable, confident, and creatively energized? First, Mediators should avoid long-winded explanations and philosophical musings – two surefire ways to lose Explorers' interest. However poetic or insightful, these conversations strike Explorers as idle chitchat, and they won't persuade them to pitch in on a human-centric project.

If they ask for assistance on a project that upholds their personal values, Mediators may be pleasantly surprised by Explorers' willingness to help – *if* Mediators frame their requests in a way that captures Explorers'

interest, that is. Wherever they stand on the workplace hierarchy, Explorers love fixing things – if a task interests them, they take it on without hesitation. Here are some hints that Mediators can use to approach their Explorer colleagues:

- When asking for help from Explorers, specify how they can act. "Can you find a way to improve our company's image?" is too vague. But, "This is driving me nuts. Can you help me find the bug on this web page?" outlines a concrete, present-moment problem that needs solving.
- Explain further only if asked. Lengthy explanations don't motivate Explorers.
- Feel free to use colloquial language, joke, and create a fun environment.
- End the conversation on a clear call to action, which is ideal for Mediators and Explorers. Both benefit from a sense of actionable urgency.
- Pay attention to how Explorers proceed, most likely taking immediate action and finding the fun or novel side of the task. Note the benefits of their approach.
- Thank Explorers for their help.

For Explorers, lofty philosophical discussions are less compelling than practical benefits and a sense of discovery. By tailoring their communications accordingly, Mediators are more likely to persuade their Explorer colleagues to collaborate on a variety of projects, including those that are close to Mediators' hearts.

Appreciation

Compassionate and creative, Mediators can use their interpersonal attunement to establish common ground with Explorers. Specifically, they can strive to translate their big ideas into the specific, tangible problems that capture Explorers' imaginations. This may not come naturally to Mediators, but it enables them to view their work from an entirely new – and uniquely helpful – perspective.

Over time, Mediators can use their empathy to cultivate a wholehearted appreciation for Explorers' perspective. Perhaps more than any other personality type, Mediators viscerally understand the value of diverse approaches. If everyone were alike, the world would be a dull, barren place – and this goes for the workplace as well. With Explorer colleagues, they can marvel at the opportunity to work with people who are wholly different from themselves. With that perspective, Explorers' behaviors – even their criticisms – are worthy of curiosity, as they offer a window into a different way of seeing the world. Here are some suggestions that can help Mediators with embracing their perspective:

- Approach Explorers with a sense of genuine curiosity.
- Seek out the lessons that they can teach, including how to take quick action and seize opportunities.
- Take notes on how Explorer colleagues behave in urgent, high-stress situations. How do they communicate? What do they do? Explorers' example can be helpful for Mediators, many of whom struggle under pressure.
- When appropriate, experiment with replicating Explorers' behavior – for example, take immediate action after a meeting rather than leaving it for another day.

When communicating and cooperating fully, Explorers and Mediators cover each other's weaknesses and complement each other's strengths. These two can tackle just about anything, and their interest in progress and innovation can unite them in unexpected yet powerful ways.

Conclusion

Mediators' strengths – including creativity, empathy, and human insight – are invaluable in many workplaces. To achieve job satisfaction, however, they must harmonize their work with their personalities. This often entails unhooking from praise and criticism, balancing social interaction with alone time, and relieving some of the pressure that they place on themselves.

In interacting with coworkers, Mediators must balance their sensitivity and optimism with the necessities of facing conflict, managing criticism, and soliciting alternative viewpoints. It isn't easy, but it's certainly achievable, and the resulting confidence and equanimity will only bolster Mediators' overall growth and development. Provided they approach work with a mindset of service and self-efficacy, Mediators can carry the resulting sense of meaning and purpose into every aspect of their lives.

Final Words

Venturing Forward

In their professional lives and in their learning experiences, Mediators are driven by creativity, curiosity, and a desire to be a force for good. People with this personality type don't particularly care about being better or more successful than other people. In Mediators' ideal world, their professional and academic interactions would allow them to foster community and collaboration, all while living up to their own standards of authenticity.

Above all, Mediators long to uncover the grand and beautiful things that dwell beneath the surface of everyday life. When they can connect their academic and professional pursuits to this longing, they're all but unstoppable. It's true that most Mediators would do well to develop their consistency and proactiveness – two strengths that can help transform their dreams into real-world actions. But their passion is a key contributor to their success – and, just as importantly, to their sense of fulfillment.

In these pages, we've seen how Mediators can bring their gifts to every aspect of their schooling and set themselves on a trajectory of lifelong learning. We've also learned how people with this personality type can bring their best selves to their careers, even when circumstances aren't ideal. For Mediators, the journey to a meaningful, inspiring professional life requires adapting to the real world without sacrificing their imagination, creativity, or optimism – all of which the world desperately needs. Our hope is that the insights in these pages will help Mediators achieve their own visions of success while appreciating – and embracing – what makes them unique.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not, dear Mediator – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you on your professional development journey? Explore our Career Specialized Tests.
- Looking to enhance your friendships, romantic relationships, or family relationships? Check out the *Mediator Guide to Relationships*.
- Ready to build a strong foundation for your self-development? Our *Mediator Guide to Personal Growth* may be just what you need.

All contents copyright ©2011–2023 NERIS Analytics Limited. All rights reserved. This document is intended for personal use only and no part of it may be translated, shared, reproduced or transmitted in any form, by any means (electronic, photocopying, recording, or otherwise) without the prior written permission of the publisher.

The publisher has used its best efforts in preparing this document, and the information provided herein is provided "as is." NERIS Analytics Limited will assume no liability nor responsibility to any person or entity with respect to any loss or damage related directly or indirectly to the information in this document (including any action or inaction taken or not taken as result of the information contained herein). Any decisions that you make once you have read this document are for you alone and we won't be liable for the consequences of any such decisions.

No warranties of any kind, express or implied, are made, and the publisher specifically disclaims any implied warranties of fitness for any particular purpose. The publisher will provide no remedy for indirect, consequential, punitive, incidental, or other damages arising from this document, including such from negligence, strict liability, or breach of warranty or contract, even after notice of the possibility of such damages.

The publisher is not engaged in rendering legal, medical, financial, or other professional services. The information in this document is educational in nature, is provided only as general information, and is not psychological advice. Transmission of this information is not intended to create, and receipt doesn't constitute a psychologist-client relationship. Furthermore, this information is not intended to be used to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease or psychological disorder.

This document is only available for purchase at https://www.16personalities.com. If you have downloaded this document from any other website or if it has been included in any service not provided by NERIS Analytics Limited, please be aware this is very likely an unauthorized copy. In such and similar cases, we would be very grateful if you could get in touch with us via our website at https://www.16personalities.com/contact-us so that we could investigate. Thank you!